

Session 2: How Jesus and the Apostles Read Their Bibles

Key Takeaways

- Jesus and his first followers portray the Hebrew Bible as a unified collection of wisdom literature that tells a story about a future anointed one who will rescue humanity.
- The Hebrew Bible is about an anointed representative who enters into suffering and death, goes through death and out the other side, and offers new life for humanity.
- By recovering a way of reading these texts that matches the contours of their design intentions, we will learn to read the Hebrew Bible as Jesus did.

Jesus and the TaNaK

Jesus and his first followers consistently portray the Hebrew Bible as a unified collection of wisdom literature that tells a forward-pointing story.

Luke 24:25-27 NIV*

²⁵ [Jesus] said to [the disciples], “How foolish you are, and how slow to believe all that the prophets have spoken! ²⁶ Did not the Messiah have to suffer these things and then enter his glory?” ²⁷ **And beginning with Moses and all the Prophets**, he explained to them what was said in all the Scriptures concerning himself.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Luke 24:44-47 NASB*

⁴⁴ Now he said to them, “These are my words which I spoke to you while I was still with you, that all things which are **written about me in the Torah of Moses and the Prophets and the Psalms** must be fulfilled.” ⁴⁵ Then he opened their minds to understand the Scriptures, ⁴⁶ and he said to them, “Thus it is written, that the Messiah would suffer and rise again from the dead the third day, ⁴⁷ and that repentance for forgiveness of sins would be proclaimed in his name to all the nations, beginning from Jerusalem.”

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

2 Timothy 3:14-17 Instructor’s Translation

¹⁴ You [Timothy], continue in the things you have learned and become convinced of, knowing from whom you have learned, ¹⁵ how from childhood you have known **the sacred scriptures** which are able to **give you wisdom** that leads to salvation through faith, which is in Messiah Jesus. ¹⁶ All Scripture is God-breathed and profitable for teaching, for reproof, for correction, for training in doing what is right, ¹⁷ so that God’s people can be proficient, equipped for doing good.

How did Jesus and his followers reach this conclusion? They did not invent this way of reading the Hebrew Bible. Rather, they inherited from their Jewish tradition a set of convictions about the origin, nature, and meaning of these texts. They also grew up in communities that modeled how to read and make sense of the Hebrew Bible.

Notice that Jesus refers to the Hebrew Bible as a two-part (“Torah ... and Prophets”) or three-part (“Torah ... Prophets ... Psalms”) collection. Jesus is not alone in this. He is expressing the most common way the Bible was referred to in Jewish culture during this period.

The Apostles and the TaNaK

Also, when we look at how Jesus and the apostles actually interpret and appeal to the Hebrew Bible, they see it as a repository of patterns or “types” (τύπος) in Greek.

Romans 5:14 NASB*

Nevertheless death reigned from Adam until Moses, even over those who had not sinned in the likeness of the offense of Adam, **who is a type/pattern** of him who was to come.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

1 Corinthians 10:1-11 NASB*

¹ For I do not want you to be unaware, brethren, that our fathers were all under the cloud and all passed through the sea; ² and all were baptized into Moses in the cloud and in the sea; ³ and all ate the same spiritual food; ⁴ and all drank the same spiritual drink, for they were drinking from a spiritual rock which followed them; and the rock was Christ. ... ¹¹ Now these things happened to them as a **type/pattern**, and **they were written for our instruction**, upon whom the ends of the ages have come.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

1 Peter 3:20-21 NASB*

²⁰ who once were disobedient, when the patience of God kept waiting in the days of Noah, during the construction of the ark, in which a few, that is, eight persons, were brought safely through the water. ²¹ A matching **type/pattern** to that, baptism now saves you—not the removal of dirt from the flesh, but an appeal to God for a good conscience—through the resurrection of Jesus Christ ...

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Reading Like Jesus and the Apostles

These passages help us set an agenda for this class.

- We will examine the writing, collection, and composition of the Hebrew Bible.
- We will recover a way of reading these texts that matches the contours of their design intentions.

Reflection Question

Summarize how you would express what Jesus and the apostles thought the Hebrew Bible was all about. And what do you make of this idea? Is it similar or different from how you typically view the Hebrew Bible?